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Culture (OWC): [Tonga \(FQ12\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1946-1947, 1948, 1950

Coverage Date: 1945-1951

Place Coverage

northeast-central Southern province, Zambia

Section Title(S): Content Of Training

This lack of direction for dealing with those outside the community is in notable contrast to the care with which children are taught correct behaviour towards those within the community. Social skills are learned in the same way by both boys and girls, with frequent instructions in etiquette—in the proper way of receiving gifts, correct ways of eating, the care of visitors, and appropriate behaviour in the usual situations which arise. Small children are not expected to have any great acquaintance with the correct usages of kinship, though at about the age of four children begin to puzzle about how different people are related to them and what term is appropriate. Then slightly older children give them considerable drill in this matter, as well as a useful corrective through laughter at mistakes. Older people do not expect children at this age to use kinship terms or to understand the references, though situations will be explained to children in kinship terms. A small child may rush home in dismay under the teasing of an old man or woman, to be told by its mother that this is appropriate joking because the teaser is his 'grandfather' or 'grandmother' and that he must joke back. From about the age of eight on children are expected, as the result of such informal instruction, to have a growing grasp of appropriate behaviour once they know the kinship category of particular people, and to be able thus to place those with whom they are in frequent contact.

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By the time a Tonga has reached adulthood and marriage, he or she has had a long apprenticeship in filling most of the various kinship roles incumbent upon him or her. This is not true, however, of some of the most significant. The kinship category of husband and wife is unique, and the individual fills such a role only on marriage. Cross-cousins and affines of the same generation may be addressed by the terms for spouse, but the content of relationship is very different. The free and easy joking which marks the

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dealings of cross-cousins is very different from the relatively restrained behaviour which spouses should observe towards one another in public. Neither type of relationship carries the same obligations or rights as that of the husband-wife relationship  269 where two individuals are expected to form a subsistence team and to build up a household of their own. In the same way, no person until she or he is married has an opportunity to occupy a role which would serve as practice for the difficult position of an affine of a lower generation, i.e., something comparable to the position of daughter-in-law or son-in-law.

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